

WEST BENGAL ORIGIN

Cholar Dal

Sweet-Savory Bengal Gram Dal
The Festive Lentil Dish of Bengal

AUTHENTIC RECIPE · STEP-BY-STEP GUIDE · PRINTABLE DIGITAL COOKBOOK

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ABOUT THIS BOOK

Cholar Dal

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Nutrition values are estimates. Cooking times vary with equipment and ingredients. Readers with allergies or dietary restrictions should check every ingredient label before cooking.

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THE STORY BEHIND THE DISH

A Dal Built for Celebration

Where most Indian dal is an everyday dish, cholar dal occupies a more festive place in the Bengali kitchen — made from chana dal (split Bengal gram, from which the dish takes its name), cooked with coconut slivers, raisins, and warm whole spices into something noticeably sweeter and richer than a typical daily lentil dish. It's the dal Bengali families reach for during Durga Puja, weddings, and other celebrations, almost always paired with luchi, puffed fried bread, rather than rice.

The distinctive sweetness comes from a combination of sugar and raisins, balanced against the earthiness of the lentils and the warmth of bay leaf, cinnamon, and cardamom — a flavor profile that sets Bengali cooking apart from the more purely savory dal traditions found elsewhere in India. Coconut, fried until golden and stirred through at the end, adds both texture and a subtle richness.

Its association with festivity runs deep enough that many Bengali households consider it incomplete to celebrate a puja or wedding breakfast without cholar dal and luchi on the table — a pairing so iconic it's become shorthand for celebration itself in Bengali food culture.

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THE STORY BEHIND THE DISH

A Dal Built for Celebration, continued

CULTURAL NOTES & OCCASIONS

A festive dish specifically associated with Durga Puja, weddings, and celebratory breakfasts, rather than everyday cooking. Almost always paired with luchi (puffed fried bread) instead of rice, a distinctly celebratory combination. Its characteristic sweetness, from sugar and raisins, sets it apart from the more purely savory dal traditions of other Indian regions. A dish so tied to celebration that its presence alone often signals a special occasion in Bengali households.

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AT A GLANCE

Equipment & preparation

10m	40m	4	Easy
ACTIVE PREP	COOK TIME	SERVINGS	DIFFICULTY

Recommended equipment

- Pressure cooker (recommended, though a covered pot works with a longer simmer)
- Small pan for the tempering
- Wooden spoon

STORAGE & MAKE-AHEAD

Cholar dal keeps refrigerated for up to 4 days and reheats well with a splash of water to loosen the consistency. It freezes well for up to 2 months — a practical make-ahead option for festive occasions when you're preparing multiple dishes at once.

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WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Ingredients

For the dal

INGREDIENT	US	METRIC	INDIAN
Chana dal (split Bengal gram)	1 cup	200 g	1 katori
Water, for cooking	3 cups	720 ml	3 katori
Turmeric powder	½ tsp	1.5 g	½ chammach
Salt	1 tsp	6 g	to taste

For the tempering & finishing

INGREDIENT	US	METRIC	INDIAN
Ghee	3 tbsp	45 g	3 chammach
Coconut, sliced into thin slivers	¼ cup	30 g	¼ katori
Raisins	2 tbsp	20 g	2 tbsp
Bay leaf	1	1	1
Cinnamon stick	1 inch	1 inch	1 inch
Green cardamom	2	2	2
Cloves	2	2	2
Dried red chili	1	1	1
Cumin seeds	½ tsp	2 g	½ chammach
Ginger paste	1 tsp	5 g	1 chammach

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WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Ingredients, continued

For the tempering & finishing (cont.)

INGREDIENT	US	METRIC	INDIAN
Sugar	2 tbsp	25 g	2 tbsp
Salt	to taste	to taste	to taste

SUBSTITUTIONS & SOURCING

Chana dal is widely available at Indian grocers and increasingly in general supermarkets' international or gluten-free aisles. Fresh coconut gives the best texture, but unsweetened dried coconut flakes, lightly toasted, work as a substitute if fresh isn't available. This dish's sugar quantity can be adjusted to taste — some households prefer a more pronounced sweetness than others, so start with less and add more if desired.

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STEP BY STEP · PART ONE

Cooking the Dal

01 RINSE AND COOK THE DAL

Rinse the chana dal and pressure cook with water, turmeric, and salt for 3–4 whistles, until soft but still holding some shape — chana dal should be tender, not mushy, for this dish.

02 CHECK THE TEXTURE

The dal should be soft enough to eat comfortably but still hold its individual grains, unlike a fully mashed dal — this distinct texture is part of what makes cholar dal recognizable.



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STEP BY STEP · PART ONE

Cooking the Dal, continued

Chef tip. slightly undercooking the dal at this stage is intentional — it will continue softening during the final simmer with the tempering.

COOKING CHECKPOINT

The dal is ready when each grain is tender enough to eat but still visibly distinct, rather than broken down into a smooth mush.

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STEP BY STEP · PART TWO

The Tempering & Sweetness

03 FRY THE COCONUT AND RAISINS

Heat ghee in a small pan and fry the coconut slivers until golden, about 1–2 minutes. Add the raisins and fry briefly until they plump up. Remove both and set aside for garnish.

04 TEMPER THE WHOLE SPICES

In the same ghee, add the bay leaf, cinnamon, cardamom, cloves, dried red chili, and cumin seeds, letting them sizzle until fragrant, about 30 seconds.



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STEP BY STEP · PART TWO

The Tempering & Sweetness, continued

05 ADD GINGER AND COMBINE WITH DAL

Stir in the ginger paste, cooking briefly until fragrant, then pour the entire tempering into the cooked dal, mixing well.

06 ADD SUGAR AND SIMMER

Stir in the sugar and simmer for 8–10 minutes, until the dal thickens to a rich, glossy consistency and the sweetness fully melds with the savory base.

Color indicator. finished cholar dal should be a warm golden-yellow, glossy from the ghee, with a consistency thicker than a typical everyday dal.

07 GARNISH AND SERVE

Top with the fried coconut slivers and raisins just before serving.

MISTAKE TO AVOID

Overcooking the dal to a smooth mush loses the distinct texture that defines cholar dal. Aim for tender but intact grains, especially since the final simmer will soften it further.

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SERVING & PAIRING

How to serve



Traditional Style

- Served with luchi (puffed fried bread), the iconic festive pairing for special occasions and puja mornings.
- A centerpiece of Durga Puja breakfasts and wedding feast menus across Bengali households.

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SERVING & PAIRING

How to serve, continued

Restaurant Presentation

- Served in a small bowl garnished with coconut and raisins, alongside luchi or plain rice.

Family Style

- A shared festive dish at the center of the table during Durga Puja or wedding celebrations.

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RESTAURANT-GRADE TRICKS

Chef secrets

Getting the Texture Right

- Slightly undercooking the dal before the final simmer preserves the distinct, non-mushy texture that's essential to this dish.
- Frying the coconut and raisins separately, rather than adding them raw, deepens their flavor considerably.

Make-Ahead & Meal Prep

- Cholar dal can be made a day ahead of a celebration and gently reheated, making it practical for entertaining.
- Fry extra coconut and raisins in advance and store separately, adding fresh just before serving for the best texture.

RESTAURANT TRICK

Some Bengali sweet shops and caterers add a small piece of asafoetida to the tempering for extra depth — a subtle addition worth experimenting with for a more complex flavor.

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BONUS CONTENT

Nutrition, variations & FAQ

APPROXIMATE NUTRITION, PER SERVING

230 kcal	9 g	30 g	9 g	7 g
CALORIES	PROTEIN	CARBOHYDRATES	FAT	FIBER

Estimates only; actual values vary with oil and portion size.

ALLERGEN GUIDE

Contains, based on the ingredient list: Dairy. Check packaged spices and asafoetida, which may contain wheat, and verify against your own ingredients.

REGIONAL VARIATIONS

Niramish Cholar Dal	a version made without ginger for strictly vegetarian temple-style cooking.
Bhoger Cholar Dal	an extra-rich version made specifically for religious offerings (bhog), often with more ghee.
Everyday Cholar Dal	a lighter, less sweet version for regular family meals rather than celebrations.

Why is my dal too sweet or not sweet enough?

Sugar levels are very much a matter of household preference — start with less than the recipe calls for and adjust to your taste.

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BONUS CONTENT

Nutrition, variations & FAQ, continued

Can I make this without coconut?

Yes, though the coconut adds an important textural and flavor element that's closely associated with this dish — even a small amount is worth including if possible.

Is cholar dal always served with luchi?

It's the most traditional pairing, especially for festive occasions, though it's also enjoyed with plain rice in everyday settings.

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REFERENCE

Ingredient glossary



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REFERENCE

Ingredient glossary, continued

GLOSSARY

Chana Dal	split, skinned Bengal gram, the base lentil for this dish.
Luchi	a puffed, deep-fried bread made from refined flour, the classic festive pairing.
Bhog	food offered to deities during religious observances, often including cholar dal.
Kansa	traditional Bengali bell metal, sometimes used for serving this dish.

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PRINTABLE RECIPE CARD

Cholar Dal

10m	40m
ACTIVE PREP	COOK TIME
4	**Easy**
SERVINGS	DIFFICULTY

DAL

Chana dal	200 g
Water	720 ml
Turmeric powder	1.5 g
Salt	6 g

TEMPERING & FINISHING

Ghee	45 g
Coconut	30 g
Raisins	20 g
Bay leaf	1
Cinnamon stick	1 inch
Green cardamom	2
Cloves	2
Dried red chili	1
Cumin seeds	2 g
Ginger paste	5 g
Sugar	25 g
Salt	to taste

METHOD

01 **Rinse and cook the dal.** Rinse the chana dal and pressure cook with water, turmeric, and salt for 3–4 whistles, until soft but still holding some shape — chana dal should be tender, not mushy, for this dish.

02 **Check the texture.** The dal should be soft enough to eat comfortably but still hold its individual grains, unlike a fully mashed dal — this distinct texture is part of what makes cholar dal recognizable.

03 **Fry the coconut and raisins.** Heat ghee in a small pan and fry the coconut slivers until golden, about 1–2 minutes.

04 **Temper the whole spices.** In the same ghee, add the bay leaf, cinnamon, cardamom, cloves, dried red chili, and cumin seeds, letting them sizzle until fragrant, about 30 seconds.

05 **Add ginger and combine with dal.** Stir in the ginger paste, cooking briefly until fragrant, then pour the entire tempering into the cooked dal, mixing well.

06 **Add sugar and simmer.** Stir in the sugar and simmer for 8–10 minutes, until the dal thickens to a rich, glossy consistency and the sweetness fully melds with the savory base.

07 **Garnish and serve.** Top with the fried coconut slivers and raisins just before serving.

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BEFORE YOU SHOP

Shopping list

☐ Chana dal	200 g	☐ Turmeric powder	1.5 g
☐ Salt	see recipe	☐ Ghee	45 g
☐ Coconut	30 g	☐ Raisins	20 g
☐ Bay leaf	1	☐ Cinnamon stick	1 inch
☐ Green cardamom	2	☐ Cloves	2
☐ Dried red chili	1	☐ Cumin seeds	2 g
☐ Ginger paste	5 g	☐ Sugar	25 g

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